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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Epstein vote in House on fast track

Speaker to expedite process, bring bill to floor early next week

By **Matt Brown**
and **Joey Cappelletti**
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The House is speeding toward a vote next week on releasing files related to the sex trafficking investigation into Jeffrey Epstein, a step that comes after months of resistance from Republican leaders.

They have no choice but to allow

consideration of the bill after a petition on the measure reached the necessary 218 signatures. It comes at a time when new documents are raising fresh questions about Epstein and his associates, including a 2019 email that Epstein wrote to a journalist that said President Donald Trump “knew about the girls.” The White House has accused Democrats of selectively leaking the emails to smear the

Republican president.

Public speculation has been rampant for years about Epstein’s operation, death and connection to powerful and wealthy individuals, including Trump, former President Bill Clinton, tech billionaires and celebrity academics, among others.

Reps. Ro Khanna, D-Calif., and Thomas Massie, R-Ky., introduced a petition in July to force a vote on

their bill, the Epstein Files Transparency Act.

The effort was backed by all House Democrats and four Republicans, including Massie and Reps. Lauren Boebert of Colorado, Marjorie Taylor Greene of Georgia and Nancy Mace of South Carolina.

Minutes after Democratic Rep. Adelita Grijalva of Arizona was sworn in Wednesday, she signed her name to the Epstein petition, pushing it to the magic number of 218 — a majority in the 435-member House.

Typically, once it reaches 218 signatures, a discharge petition must “ripen” for seven legislative days — not calendar days, but the days when the House is in session and conducting legislative business. Then, a member can call up the measure on the floor, and the speaker must schedule it for a vote within the next two days.

Massie said Wednesday night that he had checked with the House parliamentarian and

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Kennedy-King College student Oscar Rosales, 19, picks out food at the Healthy Student Market campus pantry in Chicago’s Englewood neighborhood on Nov. 6. City Colleges of Chicago’s seven main campuses each offer a free market for students to get groceries. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

SNAP benefits return as communities step up

Schools, businesses rose to challenge of helping neighbors during shutdown

By **Darcel Rockett,**
Kate Armanini
and **Hope Moses**
Chicago Tribune

Nearly 2 million people in Illinois will again receive Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program benefits starting Friday, after weeks of federal uncertainty that left families scrambling to put food on the table.

The Illinois Department of Human Services, which oversees SNAP disbursements, expects all beneficiaries to receive benefits

by Nov. 20 following the 43-day federal government shutdown.

An IDHS spokesperson in a statement told the Tribune, “This crisis was entirely avoidable — the Trump administration had the funding to fully support SNAP but chose not to, putting tens of millions of Americans at risk of hunger.”

For the 600,000 Chicagoans who rely on the program, the anxiety lingers as they question the government’s reliability as a social safety net. The current climate worries U.S. Rep. Danny

Davis, whose 7th Congressional District encompasses large swaths of the South and West sides with many elderly and low-income constituents.

“We were hurt badly,” he said, referring to social service cuts including SNAP. “We’ll be struggling to overcome, but we will and even though we come back, the impact is going to be felt for years to come.”

During the shutdown, it was communities, schools and businesses that rose to the challenge, stepping up in the face of uncer-

tainty to help their neighbors.

Grocery stores and restaurants distributed free food to those in need. Schools organized emergency food drives. And the city’s robust network of social services, nonprofits and churches expanded their ongoing operations to meet increased demand from people at every stage of life.

“We cannot ignore the fact that we have a population that needs us,” said Roni Facen, principal of St. Francis de Sales High

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INSURANCE RATES

Pritzker renews push for oversight

Calls for legislation requiring companies to justify rate hikes

By **Jeremy Gorner**
and **Olivia Olander**
Chicago Tribune

Gov. JB Pritzker on Thursday renewed his call for legislation requiring insurance companies to justify and disclose the reasons behind steep homeowners’ insurance rate hikes — a proposal that stalled in the Illinois House last month despite support from the Democratic-controlled Senate.

Pritzker said the state’s lack of authority over insurers leaves homeowners vulnerable to sharp premium increases, pointing to Bloomington-based State Farm’s decision this summer to raise home insurance rates by more than 27%. The company attributed the increases to extreme weather coupled with costly repairs.

“We’re one of very few states that doesn’t have any limits on what an insurance company can charge,” Pritzker said at an unrelated event in Chicago.

“Increases like 27% in a single year ought to be reviewed by a state regulator, and that’s all we’re asking,” Pritzker continued. “What we want is for the insurance companies simply to show us why it’s appropriate for them to raise rates by 27%. They didn’t do that. They haven’t done that. All they did was say, ‘Well, we had losses.’ ... We don’t know if homeowners are being gouged, and that’s what it feels like.”

The bill, which would have allowed the Illinois Department of Insurance to review and potentially challenge excessive or “unfairly discriminatory” rate increases, passed in the Senate 41-15 with a couple of Republicans joining Democrats in favor of the

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INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Laying groundwork for the 2026 season

Winter is coming, but the Cubs’ offseason strategy apparently is on a need-to-know basis.

Paul Sullivan in Chicago Sports

Ex-‘Inside Edition’ host has a new game

Former Chicago star Deborah Norville will preside over the newly launched syndicated game show “The Perfect Line.” **Business**

Brothers on front lines against immigration crackdown



Brothers Sam, 16, left, and Ben Luhmann, 17, patrol the streets of West Chicago and St. Charles for federal agents looking to detain people on Nov. 7. The two started patrolling Sept. 15 after federal agents targeted their heavily Latino community. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Teenagers follow, investigate, capture activity across area

By **Tess Kenny**
Chicago Tribune

With a goodbye to their mom, Sam and Ben Luhmann walked out the screen door of their West Chicago home on a recent weekday morning.

A few minutes shy of 7:30 a.m., Ben pulled their midsize sedan out of the garage as Sam stood in the driveway, adjusting the straps around his shoulders and checking his phone.

But the brothers weren’t gunning to beat the first bell at school. They were racing to find ICE.

At 16 and 17 years old, Sam and

Ben for the past two months have made it their mission to follow, investigate and capture federal immigration activity across the Chicago area. It’s an undertaking the brothers say happened naturally after growing up in a household where social justice and civic duty were as much a part of their homeschool curriculum as math and science.

“If I get the opportunity to fight like this for the rest of my life, I would be totally OK with that,” Ben said.

Their efforts in the vast resistance movement against the Trump administration’s mass deportation operation in Chicago, represent the wave of youth activists who have been galvanized into action by Midway

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